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Phil 401 – Philosophy of Art

December 19th, 2021

Transcendence of Film to Art through ‘Content-Imagination’

Some films, particularly fictional ones, are intuitively art. To discover whether this distinction is well founded I analyze Gregory Currie and his article *Anne Brontë and the Uses of Imagination*. He demonstrates why fictional novels and their ontological affect to create content-imagination and simulated beliefs qualifies those novels as art. This ‘content’ he uses within his framework can be adopted to explain why film is art. I do not believe the consequence of viewing cinematic art is because of the content, authorial intention, empathic or emotional resonance, or any formal property of the film. Currie’s ‘content’ is much more noncorporeal and adopting it to films requires understanding the relation between the viewer and the film.

Though, to be particular, ‘content’ refers to the *explicit* factors which make up a film: actors, sets, transitions, script, archetypes, camera angles, etc. I distinguish this as ‘explicit’ content to draw out another form of content. Gregory Currie describes this other form as ‘content-imagination’; referring to the act of holding an assumption in thought. He further believes this informs expectations and simulated beliefs. His framework, adopted to film, describes content-imagination as an effect in the mind of the viewers. From these imaginative beliefs individuals simulate events which may occur in the film. Similar to— yet quite distinct — to beliefs in salience and influence on behavior and understanding in any given situation. To be frank, Currie’s ‘content-imagination’ and ‘simulated-beliefs’ the audience creates when engaging with fictional novels can be expanded to encompass fictional films.

I argue that ‘content-imagination’ ontologically affects the human experience of watching film. I believe this effect in audiences is not from ‘explicit content’ but from how the intentionally fictional acts are presented as real. In other words, the viewer of fictional films has imaginary beliefs of the characters existing within a world presented to the viewer is not because of any particular content within the film. In fact, imaginary beliefs, and simulated-beliefs as consequence, form from an individual viewing an act within a film, which is explicitly fake, yet impacts the consciousness as if it were real. Furthermore, responding to film with an ontologically manifested world (in thought) ought to qualify film as art.

My definition of art, with regard to fictional film in particular, is built upon the premise that the ontological effect upon an individual is unique and subjective, but not necessarily different, for every individual. Artworks, in particular, usually impact viewers ontologically by pulling their attention from the current reality to the artifact. This ‘pulling’ is simply to describe our attention leaving the present moment of perception, and as a result, producing some response: emotional or physical. If viewers believe films to simply be the explicit content presented—there is no belief of the character— then there is no salient imaginary ontological experience; it is simply informative. However, if the characters within a film, to an extent, experience imaginary and simulated beliefs of characters from a reality presented, then the film qualifies as art.

Further adopting Currie’s argument that ‘content-imagination’ can occur prior to judgment means the manifestation of some assumptions may actually fail the film; insofar as it did not create content-imagination within the mind of the viewer. In the first film, if the assumption of Harry Potter is weak, it builds upon the accumulation of more and more

assumptions as the story develops. This means fictional films do not necessarily require impacting the individual over the entire film; just to some degree while watching a film.

Also, Currie argues a viewer holding an assumption, or imaginary ‘belief,’ in mind then uses these to ‘simulate’ events which are yet to appear. I believe films that cause more assumptions and simulated beliefs are more salient to the imaginative experience of viewers. Currie argues, for example, that assumptions based in complete fiction “are *like* beliefs” because the imagined belief, like real beliefs, have an “inferential role and affective power” on what we conclude; This similarity produces salient feelings and emotions which are reactive to the expectations and simulations which are either affirmed or denied. Each further drives the viewer to desire, and thereby, simulate more beliefs. For example, watching characters discuss that no human being, in *Lord of the Rings* (created by J.R.R. Tolkien), can withstand the corruption of ‘the one ring’ may cause viewers to simulate a belief of one of the main characters stealing the ring. Soon one scene follows where this ‘appears,’ to be the case; however, the human relinquishes his control of ‘the ring.’ Although the viewers are denied the validity of their inference it only further drives the viewer to reflect upon the memory of the scenes and expect new outcomes. Further using content-imagination to inform an experience resulting from a film.¹

Although it mostly drives the connection a viewer has to a film, affirmation and denial of inferences or expectations during a screening do not necessarily help manifest more content-imagination and simulated beliefs. The denial of an act believed to occur, usually, impacts the viewer in such a way to desire *more* information. Thus, the consequence of affirmation and denial is viewers focusing *all* attention on a fictional world. This whole-ness of attention, I believe, is caused by the film being viewed, and believed, by the viewer. The belief of the

¹ Gregory Currie. *Anne Brontë and the Uses of Imagination*. p 395.

pretended act requires the individual *and* the film. However, only fictional films simulate beliefs of scenes in such a causal and salient manner to qualify as art; how well these affirmations and denials of beliefs affect viewers is evaluative and thus, I argue, not important.

For fictional films, the created opportunity of imaginary and simulated beliefs comes from the fictional nature of the act; *pretending* to do something within film influences the viewers to have salient, yet imaginary, beliefs. From this content-imagination, Currie believes, an individual who reads a fictional novel simulates beliefs of what is yet to occur *within* that story. Readers, of course, know all the information in novels has some “special evidential relevance” to the story as whole because the author, “*for a reason*” presents it. Although this is not, to the same degree, true in film for all of its presented content, it is true enough to adapt into my framework. Chekov’s Gun for example, is a film technique used to solidify the importance of an object with the capacity to ‘go off’ in any particular sense, to go off within scenes. This is because, I believe, it is a form of affirming the content-imagination happening in the audience. I wish to adopt what Currie coins ‘simulated-belief.’ He builds this term out of simulation theory. I argue simulated beliefs demonstrate how salient films are when predictions manifest in the mind because of the act of viewing.²

Simulation, in Currie’s words, “refers to a psychological kind; a mental activity that manifests itself in different ways” for the viewer. I believe this is also true for viewers of film. The audiences’ lack of control over the pace of films, the common ground with the audience established through accumulative content-imagination and simulated-beliefs, and the only means of reliable information being the offered perspective provokes stimulatory behavior. Currie uses simulation theory to model his framework. Similar to him, I argue conceive this behavior as a

² *ibid.* 397.

natural occurring capacity of humans to understand sensual assumptions. The viewers, because of the aforementioned effects, simulate assumptions, willingly fictional, to understand a presented world as if it were real. This behavior is because of content-imagination in the mind of viewers. The imaginative beliefs provoke simulated, subjective theories. In rejection or affirmation of these personal, simulated beliefs, salient feelings, emotions, expectations, and memories form for fictional content. Under the provision that art is, in a broad sense, any artifact whose contents are imaginatively viewed and believed in such a manner that salient feelings, emotions, and opinions form when the viewer interacts with it.³

At first glance the distinction between content and content-imagination seems ineffable; the only way to put forth terms to identify the imaginative perspective of the audience for any film inherently relies on defining it by its explicit context; the parts which make up its whole. For example, in the *Harry Potter* films (created by J.K. Rowling) there are two perspectives which define what is within the film. Firstly, one can describe the content as Daniel Radcliffe, Emma Watson, and Rupert Grint wearing matching clothes, walking on a set, waving sticks, and speaking a language that does not exist. Secondly, one can describe the content imaginatively; Harry Potter is a wizard who, with his two best friends (Ron Weasley and Hermione Granger), attends a school of witchcraft and wizardry (Hogwarts) and spend their seven years of school preparing to fight a powerful dark lord. The latter impacts the imagination much more than the former strictly because the film itself allows for the opportunity of audiences to imagine something other than what it is immediately presented as. In this sense that would mean the *act of pretending* in film is what manifests the capacity for the audience to imagine and simulate beliefs on something that is not there.

³ Ibid. p 396.

Currie extrapolates the concept of imagination in the domain of fictional novels. I argue her framework can be extended further to encompass fictional films. This is because her framework relies on simulation theory and as such imagination is a defining factor of the relation between an individual's experience and film. To Currie, imagination "has an adverbial sense, where we say that this or that is done imaginatively (Scruton 1974)." Furthermore, it is also an "activity," like imagining lifting a train. Currie coins this capacity content-imagining. I agree with her distinction that imagination has a dual sense of describing action and being an action. Film is art because the imaginative capacity of the audience both defines how content is perceived and how content-imagination is simultaneously an action of perceiving those contents. For example, seeing Harry Potter as a real person (and not an actor), is both an act itself to knowingly describe the perception as something other than it is. In this example, the perception of H.P. as H.P. is formed by both an act of perception and imagination that Daniel Radcliffe is H.P.⁴

This content-imagination is exemplified in movie adaptations of novels and in films based, imaginatively speaking, in the real world. In other words, being art is not exclusive to any particular fictional film. This 'imaginative' capacity of the audience is also demonstrated by the 'universes' stories seemingly base themselves in become internalized as real by viewers. Examples include the Marvel Cinematic *Universe* (created by Stan Lee), *Middle Earth* of the *Lord of the Rings* (directed by Peter Jackson), or *Westeros* of *Game of Thrones* (created by George R.R. Martin) are all perceived as real places. Each has an imaginative setting; the audience's imagined belief is that the content is located *in* somewhere. Yet only as a result of the pretended act of being somewhere else.

⁴ Ibid. p 393.

This imaginative reality is provoked, not by the explicit content of the films, but by the audience's capacity to reason expectations and simulate beliefs to explain what is being viewed (not in terms of the real world yet placed in relation to it). Though, this reactive tendency of audiences to imagine the content of something other than its face value applies to films based in our world as well. For example, *Parasite* (Directed by Bong Joon-ho) is imaginatively believed by the audience to represent a family *in* Korea while it is nevertheless a nonexistent family. The film is art because it provokes this imaginative capacity of the audiences to see content for something it is explicitly not. The symbolism of wealthy inequality is not explicitly in the film. It is in the audience's content-imagination that relates the background of all the characters thus manifesting a comparison of wealth in simulated-beliefs.

Currie describes this capacity as being particular to fictional novels. He argues the precise "specified" content of nonfiction or strict directions within the narrative "leave no room for more or less" imagination. Conversely, within fictional stories with "a less fully specified imaginative project there are different, and differently imaginative, ways to carry" out content-imagination. The interpretation, world-building, and understanding of such perception are all imaginative. In other words, the audience's reaction to a film is imaginative in nature; as such it presents itself by all means in terms *alike* to reality yet distinct. Therefore, the setting, plot, and characters of the film are imaginatively believed to exist as a reaction to the pretended act of their existence. Almost like believing a bad lie on purpose.⁵

This definition disqualifies any nonfiction film as art. To believe a lie it must be told. Currie distinguishes this well in the aforementioned capacity of precise specific content constraining any relation to one of pure belief. Currie continues,

⁵ Ibid. p 393.

Such a project might be to engage imaginatively with a novel. In part the project involves following detailed instructions, for the novel specifies a good deal of what is to be imagined. But we will imagine many things the author does not explicitly mention, and which the work does not mandate. And where there is something uniquely appropriate to imagine, it may take an imaginative performance to see what it is.

In regard to film, some might argue the explicit content of films is presented in such a manner that the scenes have already mandated many aspects of a setting and plot which can be imagined. I argue the contrary. The content of a film, taken explicitly—at face value—presents *real* things (actors, sets, props, explosions). Yet this does not affect the content-imagination in *Harry Potter*; Harry Potter on screen would then be imaginatively believed as Daniel Radcliffe. Nevertheless, this is not the case. The audiences' context-imagination is the assumption that Daniel Radcliffe is actually Harry Potter, a famous wizard. The key distinction is that it is not Daniel Radcliffe himself who casually informs the audience to imagine he is Harry Potter.⁶

Currie offers reasoning for why these imaginative beliefs form in a capacity of the mind before judgement does. In other words, he offers a framework to explain why it is not Daniel Radcliffe the world sees but Harry Potter. Why we can imagine belief, without it becoming *real* belief (based in factual reasoning of reality), is because not all beliefs are formed from judgement and reasoning. Albeit there are some, the content-imagination Currie argues for is an assumption made distinctly before judgement; perceptions form assumptions, even fictionally, by presenting those perceptions in thought as real (viz. imagination). Continuous affirmation accumulates the authority of the perception to be important to further expectations.

In other words, “judgement requires a capacity for content-imagining” insofar as “we judge when we hold an assumption in thought” and then “consider its consequences, and its

⁶ Ibid. p 393.

relations” to the perceived truth. We can use imaginative beliefs to form judgements of nonreal activities, people, and plots without them necessarily existing. Judgement then manifests when that perceived truth “converts the assumption into a belief” which we then can confirm in content-imagination of film. The noteworthy premise is the act of “holding the assumption” in thought is the act of content-imagination; constraining an assumption to be held in thought produces salient feelings and emotions through affirmation and denial of expectations.⁷

This is why it is not the explicit content, the presentation, or directorship of film which makes it art. It is the expectation of something nonreal. The judgement of content Currie describes in the aforementioned quotations is reflective in nature. However, the act of content-imagining seems to occur and ontologically affect individuals prior to reflection; to an extent that ‘to hold’ an assumption in thought does not necessitate understanding or evaluating its validity (insofar as it is temporarily *real*). An example of this process is seeing Harry Potter (as opposed to Daniel Radcliffe), which is the act of audiences holding the assumption (Harry Potter is a wizard) without further judgement or understanding of whether this assumption is based in reality. The process and imaginative content are noncorporeal; in the sense that it is not Daniel Radcliffe; it is a completely new individual in a different, albeit similar, world.

The salience of this content-imagination magnifies in the process of viewing a film. This magnification speaks to the film's artistic nature; the accumulative process of audiences’ imagination builds the authority the film needs to further entrench viewers in assumptions, and thereby, beliefs. Just as the longer the exposure to a piece of art the more assumptions and simulated beliefs on the purpose of strokes, highlights, etc. Currie intrinsically connects this accumulative tendency of “acts of content-imagining” with “acts of pretense or limitation” of

⁷ *ibid.* p 393

presented content. Wherein “pretending to do something tends to display opportunities for imaginative behavior not displayed by the” explicit content itself, but by an act of pretending its something else.⁸

For example, in horror films the pretended act of walking towards the ominous noise in the dark basement gives the opportunity for context-imagination; that the character of the horror film is walking into a dangerous, or simply unknown, situation. Though, it is not the act of a person slowly walking into a basement which provokes audiences’ fear or anxiety. What elicits this fear and anxiety is the act of pretending to do something which is colloquially stupid (going towards the danger) creates an empty causal factor (inherent in films non-omnipotent narrative of mindsets and behavior) the viewer holds an assumption for.

Except this assumption is not of the explicit content, but the imagined content being acted and the simulated belief for why characters and plot are doing what they do. Harry Potter casting spells and getting hit by spells is inherently a pretended act. It is not the explicit effects which are the spells or the people who cast spells which sparks the imagination. It is the pretending of people to really cast and really be hit by something imaginatively (as if it were real) which sparks belief in the audience. I believe it is the desire to believe there is causal reasoning behind the pretended act which drives our simulations and content-imagination. Though, because it is pretended, the audience of films must curtail this desire to imaginative belief, otherwise the causal force causing the act is based in reality. If an individual does not particularly like magic the resulting belief would be something like, “magic would not be like that,” or “am I really supposed to believe that.” In any type of these ‘rejections’ of imaginative content, the main

⁸ Ibid. p 394.

premise is believability; however, when the content-imagination is believed the main premise is imagination (inherently fiction).

In this sense ‘assumption’ held in thought, or content-imagination, of a film is accumulative and its effects bolster the imaginative belief to simulate expectations and form new simulated beliefs. The more content, behavior, and plot the audience is exposed to the more content-imagination becomes self-referential to the world in which the story imaginatively takes place. It follows then that the more assumptions, and thereby the more imaginative processes the audience undergoes, the more a film gains authority to leave reality without the cost of assumptions being ‘dropped.’ Intergalactic space-travel, for example, is believed when it is seen, not because it is possible, but because in imagination it ought to be. Through this process, the audiences’ imagined belief, of explicit content, expects and simulates the content as if it were reality simultaneously as an act and a perception. The fictitious nature of cinematic art allows imaginative belief to form, bringing the story to life of its own inside the mind of viewers.

Though, the ‘assumptions’ held in thought have the possibility of ‘being dropped’ so to speak, as long as at least one forms the film is art. Insofar as if the illusion content-imagination offers is always shattered by a judgment of what is being watched is *explicit content* the film is not art. However, it is important to note when a film does elicit at least one assumption built in imagination that film is art. The qualification for a film being art, I argue, is defined by the capacity of a viewed film to produce content-imagination and simulated-belief; to have an inclination *like*, but not quite, a belief that who you are watching is, to some extent, *real* to the viewer.

Currie explains this process which helps fictional work sometimes hurts it when “imaginative opportunities available in the real act” may not be possible “in its pretense”,

thereby not evoking content-imagination. Instead, the viewer affirms the belief the film is of *explicit* content when presenting an act which is more imaginative in reality. If, in *Lord of the Rings*, content like harp playing was not done as it is in *reality*, there would be no room to imagine the act as imaginary; it is in its own right an art. However, in films putting ‘real imaginative acts’ only bolsters the content-imagination by affirming beliefs that the content *can* exist. Currie offers a literal example; the act of painting a picture “in imaginative ways” may not be “available if you pretend to paint.” In doing so, trying to replicate this act in a more imaginative way than real painting shatters the illusion of content-imagination. However, in a film if a *real* artist is painting in a *pretended scene* the illusion holds.⁹

In terms of non-fiction films, though, a great example is *Exit Through the Gift Shop* (directed by Banksy). This film, I would argue, is not art. It displays art, but the casual force behind provoking imaginative, subpersonal (subjective), simulated beliefs is not the documentary, but Banksy’s art itself. The documentary is just a medium. The imaginative act of painting Banksy does, and shows, are *real* in a *real setting*. There is no false pretense for audience to believe.

The key point is the presentation of Banksy’s explicit content is shown through the medium of film of reality. Conversely, a fictional film does not cause content-imagination through a medium of presentation, but forms beliefs through the imaginative capacity of thought responding to pretended actions. I argue the medium of fictional films causally forms content-imagination by appealing to subpersonal subjective simulated beliefs. In nonfiction, though, the viewer is not subject to responding with subpersonal beliefs because what is being watched is the

⁹ Ibid. 394.

truth. Fictional films require subpersonal assumptions to create a link between what is being pretended and the imaginative consequence of what may be expected.

I use Currie's 'simulated-beliefs' to define this act of memory and expectation. Currie suggests,

... that imagining involves the generation and manipulation of... 'simulated desires and beliefs'—and also simulated emotions. Simulated beliefs are not beliefs, but they are *like* beliefs... in respect of inferential role and affective power.

Because of its akin nature in 'inferential' and 'affective' factors of thought, simulated beliefs impact expectations before assumptions can be made of a fictional film. For example, worrying if Harry Potter will be killed by Voldemort is an anxiety brought about by reasoning with simulated beliefs before the assumption that he is the main character and ought to not die. Within the viewer's content-imagination there are simulated belief formations delineating what assumptions to make on expectations and what aspects of reality to omit. Thus, the imagined, although subjectively legitimate, anxiety becomes salient to the viewer while not necessarily being true.¹⁰

These salient and real effects, caused by the cinematic story being *watched*, are only possible if the viewer simulates belief; holding assumptions in thought which in turn infer, sub-personally guided, causal patterns within a film to understand what to expect. In Currie's words,

I claim that works of fiction ask us to imagine various things, and that we respond by generating appropriate simulative states which then constitute those very imaginings.¹¹

¹⁰ Ibid. 395.

¹¹ Ibid. 395.

Currie is demonstrating the capacity of novels as art is to ‘generate’ ‘simulative states’ in its readers. I argue this is transferable to films because the parameters of fictional film only represent what the viewer imagines it to. While the content presented is *real* and animate objects, the viewers internalize imaginative beliefs, assumptions based in and of fiction, to simulate what may happen. Even though it is all fictional, the stakes grow as the simulated beliefs and assumptions accumulate. Viewers only feared Harry Potter’s death because of simulative states which were constituted in the imaginative belief of J.K. Rowling’s world.

Currie elaborates that “inferences and expectations” are formulated by engagement with fictional stories. I believe this is also applicable in film. Fictional film manifests “belief-like imagination” wherein viewers use “pretend beliefs”, which are moderated by subpersonal subjectivity, to formulate the world inside their minds.

Currie transitions from this conclusion to his weakest aspect of simulated belief and content-imagination for a theory of fictional novels being art. Ironically, it is the strongest claim film has to art qualifications based in Currie’s use of simulation theory. Currie draws a distinction between when simulation is used to understand fictional works versus its more pragmatic use of understanding real people. Endangering his framework is the possibility audiences would not use simulated beliefs when engaging with fictional art.

This is because, he continues,

we would expect humans to employ simulative strategies most naturally in situations where there is little time for theorizing, where there is much in common between the parties, and where there are few other reliable sources.

Currie argues any literary text fails to meet these conditions because of the lack of constraints on the relation between reader and the story. Like the amount of time exposed. However, fictional film contains each of these qualifications.¹²

For example, cinematic film, inherent in being a ‘moving-picture,’ offers ultimately compressed time for theories. As assumptions from the viewer are held in thought, the accumulative nature of assumptions grows faster than simulated beliefs can be affirmed or denied. Understanding that Harry Potter was a horcrux is possible within the first film, however, the assumptions which manifest content-imagination of the viewer stockpile faster. Thus, the first-time viewer would never guess; adding on more simulated beliefs than answers, thereby building the authority of the imagined world to be *alike* reality.

Furthermore, within the removal of direct narrative of literary works, film seamlessly has more in common with viewers because there is inherently less information available to the viewer. Relating to Harry Potter in J.K. Rowling’s books required imaginative belief that Harry, and the reader had common ground. With more attention to detail, description, and internal beliefs Harry becomes more alienated to the reader. Relating to him when he gets his invisibility cloak would mean simulating the belief of receiving a gift from a long-passed parent.

Conversely, in the films the context-imagination which spurs from Harry’s happiness of an invisibility cloak can be simulated by the viewer because there is less known of the character.

Finally, films only have one perspective (offered by the director) in a specific sequence to be viewed. As assumptions accumulate in thought the viewer becomes subject to the authority of the perspective; the film’s view becomes *the* reliable perspective. At first, this perspective may

¹² Ibid. 396.

not contain any authority over the viewers, although usually film is attended willingly. Thus, it may be safe to assume some authority is *given* by the viewers to the presented perspective.

In other words what is being demonstrated is believed to be purposeful. The audience responds with willing choice to simulate beliefs of what might happen because of assumptions on pretended, yet purposeful, acts. The accumulation of such beliefs is affirmed and denied with very little time to realize. As a consequence, the imaginative and simulated beliefs of the film become more individualistically important to the viewer. As the story completes the imagined worlds edges are defined for the reflective capacity of humans to understand.

Although Currie then diverges from simulation theory to discuss empathy within fictional works, I will not be addressing this within the domain of fictional film. Film is art not because of the empathy derived but because of the context imagined as something other than what it *explicitly* is. His deduction of empathic capacity is intuitively evaluative; reflective upon the authorial intent of given purposes of the story and its characters. I do propose, though, the extent to which one can empathize with a film is evaluative of its artistic function to elicit content-imagination.

Fictional film has two extremes being an artwork. A truly remarkable piece of art would be a film demonstrating complete engagement of the viewer to the extent that content-imagination never ceases, thereby, simulated-beliefs (expectations and inferences) would continuously accumulate. Further building the authority of the imaginative world inside the viewers subpersonal perspective. A truly bad piece of art will continuously provoke content-imagination, to some degree, then shatter its illusion.

Distinctly the nature of this art is isolated to fictional works of film. Though, it is not isolated to only literary adaptations into film but in any content which imaginatively constricts

the viewers' time to theorize, common ground with the characters, and distinct reliability of the directors framing constitute simulated beliefs of the film. Fictional film being art, therefore, is only to the extent by which it is viewed and imaginatively viewed as something it explicitly is not.